Week 13: Biblical Law

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The Bible's laws can feel like a strange thing to study closely — tonight we'll look at what they were actually for.

1. When you hear "the Law" in the Bible, what's your gut reaction — a list of rules, ancient history that doesn't apply anymore, something else? Has your view of it changed over the years?

2. **Read Exodus 20:1-17.** What does God say about himself and about Israel before he gives a single command? How does it change the way you read the commandments that follow, knowing they come after rescue rather than before it?

3. If you had to summarize your own life's guiding "rules" the way the Ten Commandments summarize Israel's covenant, what would be on your short list?

4. **Read Leviticus 16.** What happens to the two goats in this chapter, and who is allowed to enter the Most Holy Place, and how often? What does this ritual reveal about how ancient Israel understood sin and forgiveness, and how does it shape the way you think about being forgiven?

5. **Read Leviticus 25.** What specifically happens to land, debts, and those who've been enslaved during the Year of Jubilee? Why do you think God built an economic reset like this into Israel's calendar every fifty years, and is there a version of that kind of thinking that could apply to your life or community today?

6. **Read Deuteronomy 11:18-21.** What does Moses tell Israel to do with "these words," and in what everyday moments does he say to talk about them? What practices actually help you keep the truths that matter most in front of you day to day?

7. The law codes of Israel's neighbors were often treated as monuments to a king's wisdom rather than an actual rulebook judges consulted case by case. Israel's laws, by contrast, spell out the character of the God they belonged to. How does thinking of the law as "wisdom for a covenant relationship" rather than "a rulebook to check

off" change how you approach the stranger or difficult laws in Leviticus and Deuteronomy?

8. Jesus said he came to fulfill the law, not abolish it, and summarized the whole thing as loving God and loving your neighbor as yourself. How well does that lens work for you when you run into an Old Testament law that seems strange or hard to apply today?

9. Where in your life this week would "loving your neighbor as yourself" look concretely different from what you're currently doing?